Ludvig Holberg:
Kierkegaard's Unacknowledged Mentor

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One of the brightest stars in Denmark's literary firmament, during Kierkegaard's lifetime as now, is the eighteenth-century Norwegian-born Enlightenment scholar and dramatist Ludvig Baron Holberg. He is frequently dubbed the father of Danish literature, due to the seminal impact of his dramas on the development of Danish letters and culture. F.J. Billeskov Jansen suggests that "scarcely any Dane, whether of the common people or not, is unaffected by the spriteliness and thoughtfulness that Holberg's comedies have been spreading since 1722, when, for the first time, a regular, Danish-language, popular theater was established in Copenhagen."[1] Holberg's comedies formed the basis of the repertoire of the Royal Danish Theater from its establishment in 1749; between 1722 and 1752, he wrote 33 plays, several of which have been performed consistently in Denmark ever since. Consequently, many of Holberg's characters, in particular the drunken peasant Jeppe of the Hill and the arrogant scholar Erasmus Montanus, have assumed iconic status within Danish culture.

Yet while Holberg's importance for Danish culture in general is indisputable, his specific significance for Kierkegaard is more tenuous. There are relatively few scholarly treatments of the connections between these two larger-than-life Danish thinkers,[2] perhaps because Kierkegaard himself did not acknowledge any particular stylistic or philosophical debt to Holberg, aside from making several casual allusions to various Holberg comedies in his private writings. In various works, Kierkegaard quotes from a total of 18 of Holberg's comedies, testifying to a thorough familiarity with Holberg's work. F.J. Billeskov Jansen points out that Holberg is the author most frequently quoted in Kierkegaard's writings, but cautions that Kierkegaard was generally more interested in adapting motifs and tropes from Holberg's texts than in engaging with Holberg's ideological opinions:

> The matter that Holberg provides for SK is fairly uniform: words, situations, characters of comic content and shape. But we shall see now how SK can use this material for

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[1] F.J. Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," in *Kierkegaard Literary Miscellany*, ed. by Niels Thulstrup and Marie Mikulová Thulstrup, Copenhagen: C.A. Reitzel 1981 (*Bibliotheca Kierkegaardiana*, vol. 9), p. 65.

[2] The most notable of these are Billeskov Jansen's "Holberg" and Birgit Bertung's essay "Kierkegaard og Holberg—i meddelelsesdialektisk perspektiv," *Kierkegaards inspiration. En antologi*, ed. by Birgit Bertung, Paul Müller, Fritz Norman, and Julia Watkin, Copenhagen: C.A. Reitzel 1991 (*Søren Kierkegaard Selskabets Populære Skrifter*, vol. 20), pp. 26–34.

> very varied purposes: to characterize fictional characters; in philosophical argument; in aesthetic definitions; to caricature J.L. Heiberg; as well as in religious polemic.[3]

The irrelevance suggested by this paucity of textual connections is reinforced by the dissimilarities in their lifestyles and personalities. Both men were just a generation or two removed from the peasant class, but their situations in life were marked by very disparate personal and professional circumstances. While Holberg was plagued with financial difficulties during much of his life, Kierkegaard lived comfortably, primarily through the largesse of his father and, later, his inheritance. They had very different temperaments as well, which affected both their personal and professional lives. Holberg traveled incessantly in his youth, to Germany, France, England, and Italy, whereas Kierkegaard confined himself largely to Copenhagen, aside from a few journeys to Berlin and Jutland. Holberg was upwardly mobile, climbing the academic and social ladders, currying favor with kings, and basking in the adulation of theater-goers; Kierkegaard was a highly private person who never held an academic post and reaped little praise along with a great deal of criticism and mockery for his literary efforts during his lifetime.

When their respective oeuvres and legacies are viewed from a more holistic perspective, however, Holberg appears to have functioned as a kind of mentor for Kierkegaard, albeit unacknowledged. Their relationship goes beyond simple allusions and moves into the realm of similar communicative strategies, thematic interests, and common didactic aims, many of which Holberg modeled for Kierkegaard. These similarities may be circumstantial, but provide nonetheless compelling grounds for considering the possibility of their interconnectedness. Both men's interest in literature encompassed both the aesthetic and the moral/ethical, and their works demonstrate the power of satire, irony, dialectical thinking, and Socratic-inspired indirect communication.[4] Despite their use of different genres and their focus on period-specific concerns, Holberg and Kierkegaard play a similar role in Danish intellectual history, namely, that of Denmark's itchy conscience, pointing out social problems that required public attention. They were both conservative in their views of the democratization of the political process, but not in their faith in the power of the individual to change himself and the world around him. They used their literary texts as tools for educating their countrymen and empowering them to pursue social and philosophical self-determination. Though Kierkegaard arrived at his Socratic style independently of Holberg, they were nevertheless fellow-travelers on the path of motivating their readers to take responsibility for their own lives and destinies.

I. Holberg's Biography and Significance

Born in Bergen, Norway presumably on December 3, 1684, Ludvig Holberg was destined to travel far from his origins, both social and geographic, in pursuit of the professional and artistic success he craved. He lived in a tumultuous time, marked by political and religious upheaval as well as increasing social mobility. Although

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3 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 71.

4 Bertung, "Kierkegaard og Holberg," p. 26.

his youth coincided with bitter battles between Sweden and Denmark over Norway, Holberg was a staunch supporter of the absolutist Danish crown throughout his life, in part because of the opportunities for advancement for the middle class that followed from absolutism's displacement of the old aristocracy. His parents were members of the bureaucratic middle class created by absolutism and upon which the dual monarchy of Denmark-Norway depended. His father, Christian Nielsen Holberg (1620–86), was a career civil servant with origins in the peasantry, while his mother, Karen Lem (1647–95), came from a long line of clergymen, being the granddaughter of a former bishop of Bergen, Ludvig Munthe (1597–1649). In his memoirs, Holberg points out both the noble rank of his great-grandfather as well as his father's more democratic origins: "My father, of blessed memory, rose from the ranks to the command of a regiment; and it may be inferred from this circumstance, that he was rather indebted to his personal merit than to his ancestry for his promotion."[5]

Despite the early death of his parents, Holberg was able to obtain a reasonably good education. At the age of ten, he became a scholarship student of the Upland regiment, for, as he states, "it was at the time the practice in Norway to give pay to the children of officers, and to initiate them almost from the cradle in military tactics."[6] Given his early inclination toward literature, this was not to Holberg's liking and, after a brief but disastrous interlude with private tutors in the homes of relatives, his wealthy uncle, Peder Lem, became his guardian and sent him to the Bergen Cathedral Latin School, which he attended until a fire in 1702 destroyed the school and his uncle's home. Even before the fire, Bergen's educational system was far from ideal, however, since the curriculum for the Norwegian Latin schools was outmoded and would not be reformed until 1739, when the focus was shifted from teaching Greek and Latin to more practical subjects, such as religion, reading, writing, and mathematics.[7] However, although educational reforms lagged during Holberg's youth, one educational innovation proved to be decisively important for Holberg's writings: namely, the rise of Danish as a literary language. The first Danish grammar was published in 1646 and some of its most important literary texts, along with the religious poetry of Thomas Kingo (1643–1703), would be written by Holberg himself.

Supplementing Holberg's formal education, the cosmopolitan hustle and bustle of the Hanseatic port city of Bergen offered a tantalizing introduction to other European cultures. With 15,000 inhabitants in 1700, Bergen was considerably smaller than the next-largest city in the kingdom, Copenhagen, with its 70,000 inhabitants, but it was the center of the kingdom's foreign maritime trade.[8] In his memoirs, Holberg described

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5 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs. An Eighteenth Century Danish Contribution to International Understanding*, ed. by Stewart E. Fraser, Leiden: Brill 1970, p. 24. The memoirs consist of three fictitious letters, originally published in Latin under the titles *Ad virum perillustrem. Epistola prima* (1728), *Epistola secunda* (1737), and *Epistola tertia* (1743). The standard Danish edition is the bilingual *Ludvig Holbergs tre levnedsbreve 1728–1743,* ed. and trans. by A. Kragelund, Copenhagen: Gad 1965.

6 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 24.

7 Sven H. Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg: The Cosmopolitan. A Monographic Sketch," in *Ludvig Holberg. A European Writer*, ed. by Sven H. Rossel, Amsterdam: Rodopi 1994, p. 7.

8 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 6.

the city as being, "like Noah's ark, the receptacle of all living creatures. Thither, as to common country, people of all nations, neighboring and remote, are constantly repairing."[9] This international exposure seems to have kindled Holberg's lifelong interest in travel, which took him throughout Europe and the British Isles, despite recurrent pecuniary difficulties. His travels brought their own reward, however, in broadening his intellectual and artistic horizons and providing him with material for his later work. Sven H. Rossel postulates that Holberg's travels, in particular his extended visits to England, were a major influence on the development of his literary abilities: "With Ludvig Holberg we encounter a figure who displays an insatiable appetite as a traveler, who 'does' almost all of Europe's cultural centers, and who *returns home* with an enormous intellectual enrichment."[10] Holberg summarized his *wanderlust* with the laconic remark, "The renowned author has led a stormy life. He has undertaken several journeys abroad even though he was without money."[11]

The position of penniless traveler was familiar to Holberg from his first major journey to Copenhagen to complete his studies at the university. Because of financial constraints, he completed his studies in about six months, then returned to Bergen to work as a private tutor. The work did not suit him, and so he returned to Copenhagen in the fall of 1703 for another few months of university study, earning degrees in philosophy and theology in April 1704 "with a good character, but an empty purse."[12] After another brief stint as a tutor in Bergen, Holberg began a period of extensive travel throughout Europe. To finance his initial journey to Holland, he explained, "I proceeded to turn everything I could collect into money. All my goods, chattels, and hereditaments, all my convertible property, in short, of what description soever, was sold, ceded, and alienated without remorse; like the alchemists, I endeavored to make gold from every thing."[13] Thus outfitted with 60 rix-dollars, Holberg bid farewell to Bergen for the last time and spent the next seven years primarily in the Netherlands, England, and Germany, before settling in Copenhagen in 1709.

Holberg's benefactors in Copenhagen sustained him financially as he embarked on his writing career. He became friends with several university professors, including Poul Vinding (1658–1712), professor of Greek, Christian Reitzer (1665–1736), professor of law, and Johann Burkhard Mencke (1674–1732), professor of history, all of whom helped to direct Holberg's nascent literary efforts.[14] While living at no cost in Borchs Collegium in Copenhagen, thanks to Vinding, Holberg published his first book, *Introduction to the History of the Leading European Countries*.[15] A generous scholarship to study theology allowed him to spend the years 1714 to 1716 in France and Italy. This journey, in particular with the exposure to modern French, Spanish, and Italian literature, proved to be decisive in shaping his literary style, as

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9 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 23.

10 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 9.

11 Ibid., p. 9.

12 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 30.

13 Ibid., p. 30.

14 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 12–13.

15 Ludvig Holberg, *Ludvig Holbergs Introduction til de fornemste Europæiske Rigers Historier, Forstat Indtil disse sidste Tider, Med Et tilstræckeligt Register*, vols. 1–2, Copenhagen: Bornheinrich 1711–13.

he acknowledged in his memoirs: "I confess that I owe everything to French books; for by reading these I acquired the literary taste for which my works have obtained some character."[16] Nevertheless, his next book, published in 1715, was non-fiction, an *Introduction to the Science of Natural Law and the Law of Nations*,[17] dedicated to King Frederik IV, whereas his first book had been dedicated to the crown prince, the future King Christian VI. His first major literary work, the heroic-comic epic poem *Peder Paars*, appeared pseudonymously in 1719–20 and showcased not only many of the attributes that would become hallmarks of Holberg's literary style, in particular a satirical tone, classical allusions, and slapstick-style comedy, but also many of the characters who would later secure his legacy.[18]

Over the next several decades, Holberg achieved both an academic career and prolific literary output. Two years after his return to Copenhagen, Holberg finally received the professorship at the University of Copenhagen long promised him. Since professorships were awarded by seniority rather than academic qualifications, he had to content himself with a professorship in metaphysics, which he despised, before moving up to a position in Latin poetry in 1720 and finally history in 1730, where he at last felt competent and well-situated. In later years, he played a central role in university administration, serving as rector from 1735 to 1736 and as university bursar from 1737 to 1751. His writing falls into roughly three periods: historical and scientific writings during the 1710s, dramas during the 1720s, and then a return to historical and, increasingly, philosophical texts between 1730 and 1750. Some of his most notable works from the two later periods include *Jeppe of the Hill*,[19] *The Political Tinker*,[20] *Gert the Westphaler*,[21] *The Lying-In Room*,[22] *Jacob von Thybo or the Braggart Soldier*,[23] and *Erasmus Montanus or Rasmus Berg*,[24] as well as the prose texts *Niels Klim's Underground Journey*,[25] *Epistles*,[26] and *Moral Thoughts*.[27]

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16 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 216.

17 Ludvig Holberg, *Introduction til Naturens og Folke-rettens Kundskab*, Parts 1–2 in 1 volume, Copenhagen: Johan Kruse 1715.

18 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 21.

19 Ludvig Holberg, *Jeppe paa Bjerget eller den forvandlede Bonde. Komedie i 5 Akter*, Copenhagen: Jul. Strandberg 1722.

20 Ludvig Holberg, *Den politiske Kandestøber*, Copenhagen: J.J. Høpffner 1722.

21 Ludvig Holberg, *Mester Gert Westphaler* (1722), vol. 1 in *Comoedier, sammenskrevne for den nye oprettede Danske Skue-Plads ved Hans Mickelsen, Borger og Indvaaner i Callundborg. Med Just Justesens Fortale*, vols. 1–2, Copenhagen: Trykt paa Autors Bekostning i Aarene 1723–24.

22 Ludvig Holberg, *Barselstuen* (1723), vol. 2 in *Comoedier, sammenskrevne for den nye oprettede Danske Skue-Plads ved Hans Mickelsen, Borger og Indvaaner i Callundborg. Med Just Justesens Fortale*.

23 Ludvig Holberg, *Jakob von Tyboe eller den stortalende Soldat*, Copenhagen 1723.

24 Ludvig Holberg, *Erasmus Montanus*, Copenhagen 1723.

25 Ludvig Holberg, *Nicolai Klimii iter subterraneum*, Copenhagen and Leipzig: Sumptibus Iacobi Preussii 1741.

26 Ludvig Holberg, *Epistler*, Copenhagen: Trykt paa Autors Bekostning 1748–54.

27 Ludvig Holberg, *Moralske Tanker*, Copenhagen: E.H. Berling 1744.

Holberg's continued involvement with academia alongside his dramatic writing was a wise choice, given the shifting winds of royal opinion toward the theater. When Holberg began writing dramas, the state of the Danish national theater was dire, relying primarily on traveling professional companies from abroad who performed highly dramatic historical events in a grotesque style that relied heavily on "outward, exaggerated effects, farcical elements, loud noises, and crude gestures,"[28] or French dramas in the original. While Holberg almost single-handedly accumulated a repertoire of Danish dramas for the new Danish theater, run by a Frenchman, in Lille Grønnegade during the 1720s, the royal court was one of the primary patrons, but this support varied according to the religious fervor of the individual monarch. Under King Frederik IV, the theater flourished but the great Copenhagen fire of 1728, which many people viewed as "God's punishment of a sinful city,"[29] helped to popularize pietistic religious views at court, which fostered correspondingly repressive policies toward public entertainment. In the mid-1730s, King Christian VI banned theater performances on holidays and Sundays; by 1738, actors and entertainers were not allowed to enter the country.[30] Under his son, Frederik V, however, whose regime Holberg described in a dedication to the king as "a life-loving regimen,"[31] theater performances were reinstated and Danish drama received a new lease on life when a new national theater was inaugurated in 1748.

It was neither in academia, however, nor on the stage that Holberg made either his fortune or his title. Having struggled for financial stability all of his life, he knew well the value of each coin. He lived frugally and stretched his university salary quite far, but he was also entrepreneurial in the marketing and sale of his own books and was able to amass a small fortune in this manner. His financial situation improved rapidly after 1730, when he began speculating on the stock market and in real estate. After buying two country estates, Brorupgård by Slagelse in 1740 and Tersløsegård near Sorø in 1745, he found himself not only the holder of a title, a position he had ridiculed in many of his comedies, but also a landlord, a role that he played conscientiously, implementing reforms for the benefit of his tenant farmers which also served his own ends. As he explained in his memoirs, "a prosperous peasant is generally also an industrious and competent householder, while a poor one is usually nothing more than a slothful and neglectful tenant."[32] The revenue from these estates qualified Holberg for a barony, which he obtained from the king in 1747. In 1737 he had announced his intention of "donating his fortune to the public for the advancement of the Danish language, which he did by agreeing to will his lands to historic Sorø Academy for its reestablishment as a center of Danish learning. Holberg died in Copenhagen on January 28, 1754 and was buried in the monastery chapel at Sorø, alongside several Danish kings.

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28 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 23.

29 Ibid., p. 8.

30 Ibid.

31 Quoted in ibid.

32 Ludvig Holberg, *Epistler*, vols. 1–8, ed. by F.J. Billeskov Jansen, Copenhagen: Hagerup 1944–55, vol. 1, p. 329.

Holberg's significance for Danish culture is difficult to overstate, particularly when one looks deeper than just at his popular dramas. For, in addition to providing centuries' worth of entertaining comedies and laying the foundation for Denmark's impressive theatrical tradition, Holberg demonstrated how literature could be used as a tool both to enhance international opinion of Dano-Norwegian culture and to shape the mentality of the citizens of the Dano-Norwegian kingdom. Rossel argues for Holberg's unprecedented achievements with regard to improving the quality and status of Danish literature:

> With his writings Holberg in fact raised a backward and provincial Dano-Norwegian culture with an almost nonexistent dramatic literature to a contemporary and international level. Holberg should rightly be seen, as he always has been, as the father of Danish and Norwegian literature, instrumental in opening the door for Denmark and Norway onto the rest of Europe.[33]

Holberg himself focused more on the domestic impact of his writings, congratulating himself that "our Danish plays have remoulded the common people of these kingdoms into another form and taught them to reason upon vices and virtues, about which many had previously very little idea."[34] His writings often aroused controversy, but always provoked critical thinking about social conditions. For example, his satirical text *Zille Hans-daughter's Gynaicologia or Defense of Womankind*[35] offered a "radical assertion for its time of women's equality not only with regard to education, but also in filling public office."[36] For centuries, scholars have struggled to categorize his ideological position. His fierce attacks on what he perceived as "affected" and "unnatural" ideas, including Catholicism, have led some scholars to characterize him as "radical," "anti-authoritarian," "progressive," and "democratic," while others point to his insistence on a centralized, rational form of government such as absolutism as evidence that he was, in fact, more "conservative," "reactionary," and "paternalistic."[37] Overarching these disagreements, however, is widespread consensus that Holberg was a highly critical thinker whose contributions to Danish intellectual life consist of more than just his comedic dramas.

Despite the popular acclaim that Holberg enjoys today, the reception of his works and ideas in Golden Age Copenhagen is more problematic and undoubtedly contributed to Kierkegaard's conscious opinion of Holberg. In a survey of Holberg's shifting reception and interpretation in Scandinavia across the centuries, Bent Holm notes that even though Holberg's comedies remained popular among the peasantry in the early nineteenth century, the Copenhagen elite either regarded him as an author for the lower classes or whitewashed his satirical and socially critical stances,

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33 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 39.

34 Quoted in Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 65.

35 Ludvig Holberg, *Zille Hans Dotters Gynaicologia eller Forsvars Skrift for Qvinde-Kiønnet*, Copenhagen: Joachim Wielandt 1720.

36 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 22.

37 Bent Holm, "Ludvig Holberg and His Double: Holberg in Scandinavia," *Ludvig Holberg: A European Writer,* ed. by Sven H. Rossel, Amsterdam: Rodopi 1994, pp. 191–2.

transforming him into "a purely historical figure."[38] Holberg's down-to-earth attitude and earthy humor clashed with the idealistic, sanitized values of national Romanticism and his direct engagement with questions of political and social power struggles appeared vulgar and coarse in light of the Golden Age distaste for political involvement. Yet it is precisely this willingness to engage with unpopular but indispensable topics that Holberg had in common with that most prominent Golden Age misfit, Kierkegaard himself.

II. Kierkegaard's Indebtedness to Holberg

It is unclear exactly when Kierkegaard first encountered Holberg's works, possibly while a pupil at "Borgerdydskolen," but most certainly at the Royal Theater while a student at the University of Copenhagen in the late 1820s and 1830s. In his journal for the year 1834, he refers to several pieces by Holberg which were performed at the Royal Theater that spring, including *Jacob von Thyboe*, performed on April 23, 1834, and *The Fussy Man*, performed on March 14 and October 12, 1834.[39] In both a lengthy footnote in *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* and a journal entry from 1843, he mentions "Holberg's Ulysses, who was also the man of the hour," in reference to Holberg's comedy *Ulysses von Ithacia* (1725), which had not been performed at the Royal Theater since March 1835 but was included in the seven-volume collection of Holberg's comedies, *The Danish Theater*,[40] that Kierkegaard owned, along with copies of *Peder Paars* and *Niels Klim,*[41] as well as several biographical and reference works that discuss Holberg's life.

Kierkegaard readily acknowledged Holberg's foundational position in the Danish literary canon, in particular as a source of ideas for contemporary writers. In *Stages on Life's Way,* he cites Holberg, along with Holy Writ, as an impeccable reference for linguistic tradition, arguing, "When there is need, one should not shy away from using the descriptive terms that both the Bible and Holberg use."[42] In his journal in 1837, he describes Holberg as "our literary fountainhead,"[43] the source of Danish literature, and proposes conducting an experiment to determine, based on Holberg's comedic works, what people in different age groups find amusing. He reiterates this view in the reply he composed—but never published—to an attack on him in the *Humoristiske Intelligentsblade* in May 1836, in which he accuses Johannes Hage (1800–37), the editor of the newspaper *Fædrelandet,* of borrowing ideas from Holberg, among others, in an attempt to maintain the creativity of his work: "It isn't just at Holberg's much frequented pawnshop that he borrows on credit. It isn't just among well-known and unknown authors, no, it's even with friends and

38 Ibid., p. 203.

39 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," pp. 67–8.

40 Ludvig Holberg, *Den danske Skue-Plads, deelt Udi 7 Tomer*, Parts 1–7 in vols. 1–2, Copenhagen: J.J. Høpffner [1788] (*ASKB* 1566–1567).

41 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 79.

42 *SKS* 6, 272 / *SLW*, 293.

43 *SKS* 17, 240, DD:55 / *KJN* 1, 231.

acquaintances!"[44] Yet Kierkegaard also found inspiration in Holberg's work for his own on at least one occasion. In his notebook from 1849, Kierkegaard explored the idea of writing a parody of a scene from Holberg's drama *The Happy Shipwreck*,[45] tentatively entitled "A Strange Encounter," in which two servants meet to discuss the curious discrepancy between the courage of the apostle Paul in the year 48 and the accolades accorded priests in 1848 for just talking about Paul's bravery.[46]

Kierkegaard occasionally used phrases and words from Holberg's works as well. In *The Concept of Anxiety*, Kierkegaard uses the term "Projektmagere," i.e., project makers,[47] a derogatory term often used by Holberg in the novel *Niels Klim* to denote individuals who consistently conceive of useless or impossible projects.[48] Aimed at a European audience, Holberg's novel appeared originally in Latin under the title *Nicolai Klimii Iter subterraneum* in 1741, but Kierkegaard, despite his fabled competency in Latin, apparently read it in Danish in Jens Baggesen's lively translation from 1789.[49] In his notebook in 1849, Kierkegaard refers to the pastry Niels Klim lost as he fell toward the center of the earth,[50] which is consistent with the Baggesen translation, although the original, and N.V. Dorph's 1841 translation, uses the word "*panem*" or "bread." In *Stages on Life's Way*, Kierkegaard uses the Latin expression "*lectori benevolo*" [to the willing reader], that Holberg used in the introduction to *Peder Paars* (1719–20).[51] Kierkegaard also uses the phrase "*mundus vult decipi*" on several occasions in his notebooks,[52] an expression about which Holberg recounted a historical anecdote in his *Several Comparative Histories and Deeds of Various Great Heroes*.[53] In the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript,* Kierkegaard uses the phrase "the world will not last until Easter," an expression which Holberg often used.[54]

In general, however, Kierkegaard's published works offer little material for an investigation of his indebtedness to Holberg, since most of Kierkegaard's explicit references to Holberg and his works occur in his journals, private correspondence, or footnotes to his published and unpublished works. These references range from brief, general asides, such as the comment in a journal entry from 1837, "This is something Holberg has so excellently perceived,"[55] to more detailed allusions to

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44 *SKS* 17, 38, AA:21 / *KJN* 1, 33

45 Ludvig Holberg, *Det lykkelige Skibbrud*, Copenhagen 1724.

46 SKS 22, 176, NB12:60.a.

47 *SKS* 4, 230 / *PF*, 21.

48 Ludvig Holberg, *Niels Klims Underjordiske Reise. Efter Holbergs latinske Original*, trans. by Jens Baggesen, in *Jens Baggesens danske Værker*, vols. 1–12, ed. by the sons of the author and C.J. Boye, Copenhagen: Andreas Seidelin 1827–32, vol. 12, pp. 165–524, see pp. 387ff.

49 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 80.

50 SKS 20, 418, NB14:128.

51 *SKS* 6, 11 / *SLW*, 4.

52 *SKS* 20, 40, NB:36. *SKS* 20, 47, NB:47.

53 See *Ludvig Holbergs udvalgte Skrifter*, vols. 1–21, ed. by Knud Lyhne Rahbek, Copenhagen: J.F. Schultz 1804–14, vol. 9, p. 86 (first edition, see Ludvig Holberg, *Adskillige store Heltes...sammenlignede Historier og Bedrifter*, Copenhagen: E.H. Berling 1739).

54 See *SKS* 7, 330 / *CUP1*, 362.

55 *SKS* 17, 47, AA:32 / *KJN* 1, 40.

specific characters in individual works, including a wide range of characters from the comedies as well as figures that appear in Holberg's historical works. On the basis of these entries, Billeskov Jansen asserts that Kierkegaard's relation to Holberg gradually transforms from identification with Holberg's characters, in particular the misunderstood protagonist of *The Fussy Man*, to appreciation for Holberg's ability to balance pathos and comedy through wit. After the *Corsair* affair, however, when Kierkegaard found himself the butt of the kind of jokes that pervade Holberg's comedies, he became more critical of Holberg's humor, noting in his journal in 1849: "Really, though, there is something low, simple-minded in most of Holberg's comedy...for it depends on the quite ordinary, human, teasing and guffawing malice."[56]

In the most significant instances where he refers to Holberg's works, Kierkegaard draws on Holberg's plays for examples to illustrate concepts with which he was currently grappling. One of the thematic areas in which Kierkegaard found Holberg most relevant regarded the relation between the comic and the tragic in drama. In his journal Kierkegaard speculated about the aesthetic paradox that might be created by the unexpected death of a ridiculous character, such as Jacob von Thyboe in Holberg's comedy of the same name: "Would Jacob von Thyboe, if we were to think of him dying by tripping over his spurs in the fifth act...become [a] traged[y]?"[57] The possibility of the tragic existing within comedy fascinated Kierkegaard and drew him to Holberg's plays, in particular *Erasmus Montanus.* On January 19, 1835, Kierkegaard noted in his journal, "The proximity of the tragic to the comic (an observation particularly attributable to Holberg's use of comedy—for example his *Jeppe paa Bjerget* [Jeppe of the Hill], *Erasmus Montanus*, *Den Stundesløse* [The Fussy Man], etc.)—seems to account also for the fact that a person can *laugh until he begins to cry.*"[58] Despite or perhaps precisely because of Kierkegaard's failure to master the genre of dramatic comedy, he looked to Holberg for the incarnation of his own theoretical ideas. Self-reflection is another area where Holberg's characters provided the framework for Kierkegaard's thoughts. In connection with his examination of himself as a philosopher in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Kierkegaard muses: "Thus abstract thinking helps me with my immortality by killing me as a particular existing individual and then making me immortal and therefore helps somewhat as in Holberg the doctor took the patient's life with his medicine—but also drove out the fever."[59]

Yet the key to the mentoring relationship between Holberg and Kierkegaard can perhaps best be found in Kierkegaard's attitude toward Holberg himself, as revealed in textual references which confirm his respect for Holberg's rhetorical acumen and suggest that he was not unaware of the similarities between them and their self-selected tasks of showing society the error of its ways. In the journal entry "Something about Hamann" from 1837, Kierkegaard notes:

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56 *SKS* 22, 416, NB14:126; Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 81.

57 *Pap*. I A 25 / *JP* 4, 4822. See also *Pap*. I A 209 / *JP* 4, 4824 for a similar comment.

58 *Pap*. I A 34 / *JP* 4, 4823.

59 *SKS* 7, 275 / *CUP1*, 302.

> I hope furthermore that it will be abundantly evident that every man who in the real sense is to fulfill an historical epoch must always begin polemically, precisely because a subsequent stage is not the pure and simple consequences of what has gone before. Wasn't this the case with Holberg? with Goethe? with Kant, etc. etc.?[60]

Kierkegaard's categorization of Holberg, together with Goethe and Kant, as a "man who is...to fulfill an historical epoch" conveys his admiration for Holberg's abilities and significance, as well as his familiarity with Holberg's biography and writings outside of his comedies. The public display of Holberg's polemical skills to which Kierkegaard is most likely referring in this passage occurred in 1719, at the beginning of Holberg's career, when he was accused of having plagiarized his first book, *Introduction to the History of the Leading European Countries*, by Andreas Hojer (1690–1739), a doctor, lawyer, and historian in Schleswig and author of *A Brief History of Denmark*.[61] Over the course of the exchange of accusations and polemical arguments, Holberg discovered his gift for writing satire. In his memoirs, he explains, "In replying to a satirical production, I became a satirist myself,"[62] a skill which would serve him well in his dramatic and poetic writing. Kierkegaard may have identified with Holberg's sentiment, as he too discovered his polemical talent in the exercise of it, though his satirical works, unlike Holberg's, did not generally take the form of comedic dramas and poems, but rather essays.

Holberg and Kierkegaard shared not only a fondness for satire and a keen recognition of its effectiveness, but also a deep investment in empowering their audiences, even at their own expense. Like Kierkegaard, Holberg used pseudonyms on several occasions, not because he could really expect to conceal his authorship of particular texts from the tight-knit intellectual circles in Copenhagen, but because of the rhetorical possibilities such a move made possible, in particular the opportunity of discussing his own works from the perspective of an observer and thus reaching his audience on a different level than in the work itself. Holberg's first major literary works, *Peder Paars*[63] and *Four Satirical Poems* with *Two Prefaces* as well as *Zille Hans-Daughter's Defense of Womankind*[64] were published under the pseudonym Hans Mikkelsen and struck a deliberately provocative tone. *Peder Paars* is both a parody of Virgil's *Aeneid* and a satire of Danish society, as seen in microcosmic form on the island of Anholt, while the *Four Satirical Poems* includes a *Critique of Peder Paars*,[65] in which Holberg defends his own satirical poem "by stressing, in perfect

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60 *SKS* 17, 209, CC:25 / *KJN* 1, 200.

61 [Andreas Hojer], *Andreæ Hojern Kurtzgefasste Dännemärckische Geschichte: Vom Anfang dieses mächtigen Reichs Bis zum Ausgang des XVII. Seculi; Aus den bewährtesten Scribenten zu mehrerer Deutlichkeit in Fragen und Antworten verfasset, Und mit nöthigen Allegationibus versehen*, Flensburg: Bosseck 1719.

62 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 99.

63 Ludvig Holberg, *Peder Pars: poema heroica-comicum*, Copenhagen: P.J. Phoenixberg 1720.

64 Ludvig Holberg, *Hans Mikkelsens fire Skiemte-Digte med Tvende Fortaler, samt Sille Hans Dotters Forsvars-Skrift for Qvinde-Kiønned*, Copenhagen: Joachim Wielandt 1722.

65 Ibid.

accordance with rationalism, its usefulness."[66] In the resulting uproar, Holberg drew intense criticism and alienated some of his friends,[67] an experience that Kierkegaard would repeat to his own chagrin during the *Corsair* affair.

Perhaps as a result of such personal experiences with public scorn and humiliation, both Kierkegaard and Holberg were, understandably, skeptical about the wholesale democratization of political power, though not of the necessary intellectual emancipation of the common man. Holberg was a staunch supporter of Denmark's absolutist political system, but his comedies exhibit distinctly anti-aristocratic leanings as well, suggesting that his support of the privileged elite was neither unqualified nor uncritical. He believed in the necessity of a firm hand at the helm of the ship of state, but with the support of the people, not at their expense. Holberg's enthusiasm for a rational, paternalistic government was moderated by his basic trust in human nature, a conviction that Kierkegaard shared, though Kierkegaard's trust in the individual was tempered by his fear of the undifferentiated crowd. Billeskov Jansen draws attention to Kierkegaard's journal entry about *Erasmus Montanus* on December 2, 1837 where he laments, "I weep when I see or read Erasmus Montanus; he is right and is subdued by *the mass*. Yes, that is the point. When every confirmed glutton is given the franchise, when plurality of votes decides the issues—is not one then subdued by the mass, by fatheads?"[68] However, this fear of mob rule did not dissuade either Kierkegaard or Holberg from investing himself in bringing about the intellectual and philosophical empowerment of the common man in Denmark. On the contrary, they regarded their efforts as integral to the liberation of the individual from the unthinking masses.

Both Kierkegaard and Holberg were educated in the classical tradition and drew on antiquity for inspiration, but they were also instrumental in the modernization of Danish literature and intellectual culture. Their works are replete with references to biblical and classical literature, but they are also, with a few strategic exceptions on Holberg's part, written in Danish, which, despite the century separating Holberg's dramas and Kierkegaard's doctoral dissertation, was still revolutionary. Holberg helped to establish Danish as a literary language and, in turn, Kierkegaard built on this foundation to make Danish capable of conveying complex philosophical concepts, in particular Socratic irony and dialectical thinking, of which Holberg had also made use, though not as systematically.

Socrates thus represents one of the most compelling links between Holberg and Kierkegaard, guiding them both to develop methods of indirect communication that would motivate their listeners to reach their own conclusions and act on them. Each was attracted to indirect communication for different reasons, as Birgit Bertung explains, "Kierkegaard because he believed that existential truths could not be transmitted to others directly, and Holberg because he believed that 'the moral is the most effective thing and has the greatest effect.' "[69] Yet they shared the conviction that it is the philosopher's task to function as a teacher; Holberg explained, "it is in this regard

66 Rossel, "Ludvig Holberg," p. 22.
67 *Ludvig Holberg's Memoirs*, p. 100.
68 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 70.
69 Bertung, "Kierkegaard og Holberg," p. 26, my translation.

that I recommend paradoxical opinions."[70] To this end, both employed a wide range of genres and narrative styles to get their message across to the common man. For example, although Holberg relied heavily on comedies to demonstrate the follies and virtues he wanted to make his audience aware of, he also tried his hand at fables and parables, much like those Kierkegaard made use of in his attack on Christendom.

Although Holberg's name is rarely mentioned in connection with Kierkegaard's religious writings, religion was in fact one of the areas where their interests overlapped, though there are few indications of Kierkegaard having studied Holberg's theological writings. Billeskov Jansen attempts to explain this gap by suggesting that Kierkegaard was simply unfamiliar with Holberg's philosophical and historical works, particularly *Moral Thoughts* and *Epistles*.[71] However, there are still several points at which Kierkegaard draws on Holberg to legitimize his own struggle against the Danish State Church, suggesting that Kierkegaard regarded Holberg as a compatriot in his struggle to facilitate the emancipation of the minds and souls of the Danish people. In " 'Guilty?'/'Not Guilty?' " in *Stages on Life's Way,* for example, Kierkegaard refers to both Holberg's *General History of the Church*[72] and his *Several Comparative Histories and Deeds of Various Great Heroes*.[73] In both cases, Kierkegaard selects examples of pagans whose relationship to Christianity is strained by the excesses of Christendom. From the former, Kierkegaard cites the story of King Radbodus of the Goths (died 719) who decided against being baptized by the missionary Wulfranus in order to be together with his pagan, and hence damned, forefathers in the afterlife. From the latter work, he recounts the fear of Spanish brutality among the native peoples of Mexico that led them to reject the Christian heaven if Spaniards would be there as well.[74] Although the theological content of these examples is vanishingly small, the consistency is clear between Holberg's critical account of Europe's checkered religious history and Kierkegaard's desperate determination to challenge the hegemony of the ecclesiastical culture rooted in that history.

In 1851, Kierkegaard wrote that "we Danes live approximately in such a way that Holberg is the wisdom we live by."[75] However tongue-in-cheek this comment might have been intended, it brings into focus the fact that Kierkegaard's indebtedness to Holberg is twofold: first, as a member of the Danish culture to which Holberg contributed so much; and second, as an author trying to shape his own ideas and looking to his predecessors for inspiration. The multiplicity of ways and contexts in which Kierkegaard encountered Holberg testifies to the enduring effectiveness of Holberg's strategy of indirect communication, which Kierkegaard perfected. It would be impossible to unravel the knot of allusions and affinities between Kierkegaard

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70 Ludvig Holberg, *Moralske Tanker*, ed. by F.J. Billeskov Jansen, Copenhagen: H. Hagerup 1943, p. 24.

71 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 76.

72 Ludvig Holberg, *Almindelig Kirke-Historie. Fra Christendomens første Begyndelse, Til Lutheri Reformation, Med nogle Anmærkninger Over de udi Historien omtalte Cyclis og Aars-Beregninger*, vols. 1–2, Copenhagen: Trykt udi Hans Kongel. Majestaets og Universitets Bogtrykkerie, af Johann Georg Høpffner 1738.

73 *SKS* 6, 241 / *SLW*, 259.

74 Ibid.

75 Billeskov Jansen, "Holberg," p. 81.

and Holberg in such a way as to determine precisely how and when Holberg's works might have influenced Kierkegaard, but such an exercise is unnecessary, for the deed is done either way. Holberg and Kierkegaard shared enough values, ideas, techniques, and opinions to complement each other well, regardless of whether Holberg's mentoring role in Kierkegaard's development is explicitly acknowledged or merely implied.

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